Notification Manager+

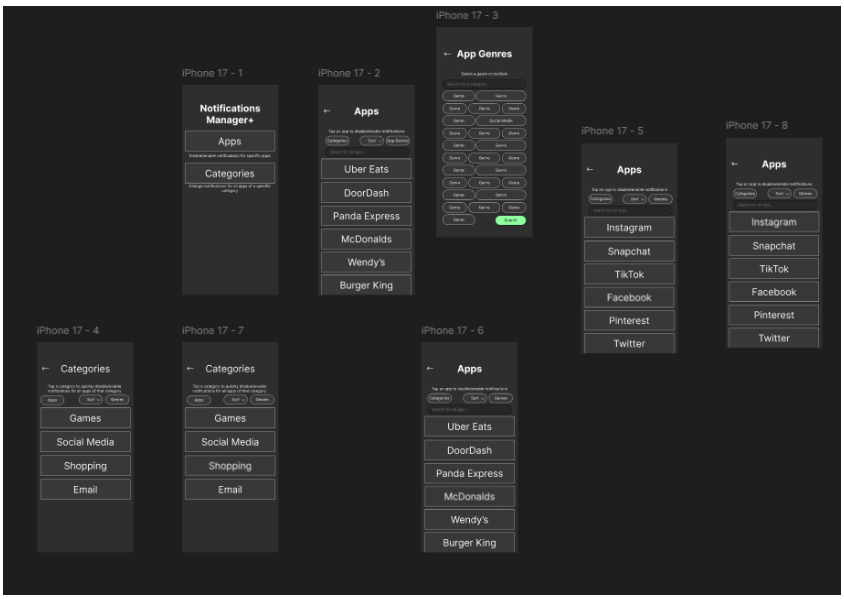
UX Case Study | Jason Pondel | UXD210

UX Design · Solo Project · Usability Testing + Figma Prototyping

1. Hook

Smartphones light up with dozens of notifications daily, but mobile operating systems offer little flexibility in how users manage them. Notification Manager+ explores a more intuitive approach, giving users granular control over which apps can reach them, and when.

For this project, I served as the sole UX designer, responsible for prototyping, recruiting participants, conducting usability testing, and reiterating findings. Using a think-aloud protocol with three users, I identified key navigation pain points and redesigned the interface to resolve them.



Key Results

All three users successfully completed core tasks, and testing brought up two insights; confusion between the "Apps" and "Categories" tabs, and ambiguity around the "Genres" label.

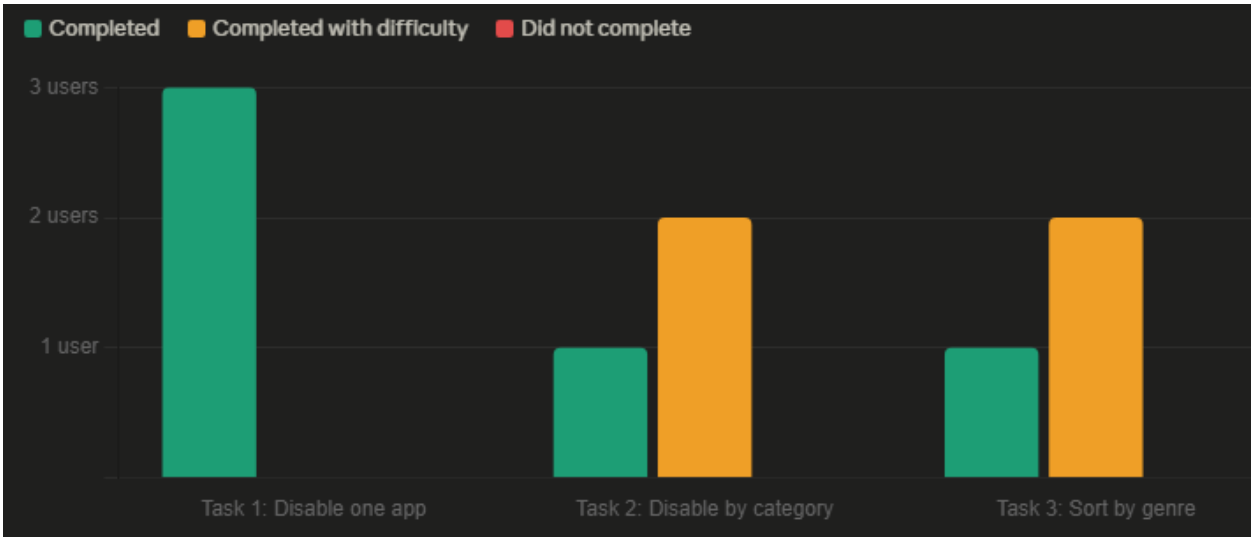
2. Research

The goal of this study was to evaluate whether users could navigate Notification Manager+ intuitively across three core tasks:

- Disabling notifications for a single specific app

- Disabling all notifications within a shopping category at once
- Comparing and toggling notifications for two apps by genre

I recruited three participants and used a think-aloud protocol, asking each to verbalize their thought process as they worked through the tasks. This method was chosen specifically because it surfaces *why* users make navigation decisions.



What the Research Revealed

Task 1 proved straightforward for all users, confirming that individual app management was intuitive. However, Tasks 2 and 3 exposed a recurring theme: users weren't distinguishing between "Apps" and "Categories" the way the interface intended. Two of three participants navigated to the wrong tab when trying to disable an entire category at once, and two struggled to locate genre-based sorting. This let me know that "Genres" wasn't communicating its purpose clearly.

3. Sketches & Wireframing

Early design work for Notification Manager+ focused on establishing a clear information hierarchy. The core challenge was organizing notification controls into a structure that felt simple, separating individual app management from broader category-level controls without creating confusion between the two.

Initial wireframes mapped out three primary views: the main menu with tab navigation, the Apps list, and the Categories view. The rough prototype used in testing was built directly in Figma, allowing for interactive flows that could be evaluated with real users before committing to a high-fidelity design.

4. Prototyping & Iteration

With the usability findings in hand, I returned to Figma in order to close the gap between how the interface was structured and how users actually think.

The rough prototype had established a solid foundation, but the testing revealed that two areas needed rethinking before the design could be considered truly intuitive.

What I Changed, and Why

- **Tab descriptions on the main menu** — Users 2 and 3 both bypassed "Categories" entirely, heading straight to "Apps" when asked to disable a group of notifications. Rather than restructuring the navigation, I added short descriptions beneath each tab label so users could immediately understand the distinction without having to explore first.
- **A search bar in the Apps section** — While no participant explicitly requested this during testing, the sessions made clear that scanning a long app list was a friction point waiting to happen at a larger scale.
- **"Genres" renamed "App Genres"** — The original label was too close to "Categories" in feel, contributing to the confusion users experienced in Task 3. The added specificity makes the two feel distinct.
- **A quick-swap between Apps and Categories** — If a user realizes mid-browse that they want the other view, they shouldn't have to navigate back to the main menu. This change respects the user's flow and reduces unnecessary steps.

5. Outcomes & Lessons Learned

Notification Manager+ achieved its core goal: a notification management interface that users can navigate quickly and complete tasks within without confusion. All three participants moved through the app with confidence, and the pain points uncovered during testing had clear, actionable solutions.

The most valuable outcome was what the process revealed about assumption-making in design.

What I Took Away

Going into testing, I assumed the distinction between "Apps" and "Categories" was self-evident. It wasn't. Two of three users made the same wrong turn, which told me the issue wasn't user error — it was a labeling and hierarchy problem I had overlooked because I was too close to my own design. That realization was the turning point of the project.

It reinforced something I'll carry into every project going forward: the designer's logic and the user's logic are not the same thing. No amount of careful structuring replaces watching a real person interact with your work.